The Comfort Kit

Civic Skill: Empathy | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 2 (Community) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will practise perspective-taking by imagining what might comfort someone else, distinguishing their own preferences from another person's needs.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can think of something that helps me feel better when I'm sad.
- I can think about what might help someone else, even if it's different from what I'd choose.
- I can explain why I chose something for someone else.

MATERIALS

- One small box or decorated bag per child (or one shared group box)
- Collection of comfort items: a small soft toy, a piece of fabric, a photo of something natural, a drawing prompt card, a simple instrument (triangle), a pinwheel
- Picture book: 'The Invisible String' by Patrice Karst or 'Strictly No Elephants' by Lisa Mantchev
- Drawing paper and crayons

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. OPENING STORY (5 min): Read 'The Invisible String.' Ask: 'What helps you feel better when someone you love isn't there?' Take 3–4 responses. Normalise different answers.

2. INTRODUCE THE COMFORT KIT (3 min): Show the collection of items. 'We're going to make a comfort kit — not for us, but for a friend who is feeling sad. The tricky part? We have to think about THEM, not just what WE like.'

3. BUILDING THE KIT (10 min): Children select 2–3 items. Before placing each one, they must say: 'I'm choosing this because my friend might feel ___ when they hold/see/hear it.' Educator gently probes: 'Is that what YOU like, or what THEY might like? How do you know?'

4. PAIR SHARE (5 min): Children share their kit with a partner. Partner responds: 'I think this would/wouldn't help me because ___.' Encourage gentle disagreement — the point is that different things help different people.

5. CLOSING REFLECTION (5 min): Whole group: 'Did anyone choose something for their friend that's different from what you'd choose for yourself? That's the hardest kind of caring — caring in the way someone else needs, not just the way you'd want.'

EXTENSIONS

- Children write/dictate a card to go with the comfort kit explaining each item choice
- Role-play: one child pretends to be upset, another offers the kit and watches for the response
- Connect to real life: make a classroom comfort corner together with items chosen by the group for the group

ASSESSMENT

- Observation: Does the child distinguish between their own preference and someone else's when explaining their choices?
- Questioning: Ask individual children, 'Why did you put that in?' and note whether they reference the other person's perspective
- Documentation: Photograph the kit with a transcribed explanation — this is a strong learning story artefact

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Were children able to separate their own preferences from another's needs? At what point did they need support?
- Which part of the activity generated the richest language about others' feelings?

- How might you use this kit idea in everyday moments of conflict or upset throughout the week?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 2 (Community). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.